

M2.1a Decision Making

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Social Studies_7-9

You Can't Handle the Truth

In this lesson we cover how humans are bad at seeing the truth for what it is, our natural tendency is to take mental shortcuts. Where that often serves us well we should be mindful of when and how we are doing it.

Overarching Question:
What are the limitations we have when deciding whether to believe in conspiracies?

Objectives:

M1.2 Class 1

Standards:

Stage 1: Identification – Meta-Analysis of Decision Making

Goal: Identify the decision of choosing a capstone project for the course and reflect on its impact for the semester.

- You are selecting a capstone project that will be the focus of your work throughout the entire semester. This decision will shape not only what you study, but how you approach research, critical thinking, and the development of your final presentation.

    - **Question 1: What do you think makes a strong capstone project? Consider factors like your interest, the availability of research, and the complexity of the topic.**

    - **Question 2: How do you want this project to challenge you? (Think about skills you want to develop: research, analysis, writing, presenting, critical thinking.)**

    - **Question 3: How does choosing this project now affect the direction of**

your work for the semester? (Think about the long-term impact of your choice. What kind of project will keep you engaged? What type of project will allow you to explore the most interesting questions?)

- Were there any biases
  - Did you consider the strongest counterarguments
    - Explain how your final choice may have been influenced by your initial interest
      - Describe why you feel confident in your choice.

5. Research availability: How easy will it be to find credible sources for both the official story and conspiracy?
6. Interest level: How much do you personally care about this theory?
7. Complexity of competing hypotheses: How many plausible explanations can be found for this theory?
8. Group or individual work: Consider whether this project would be better suited to working in a group or individually. Reflect on how collaboration (or working alone) might enhance your ability to critically analyze the theory.

Rubric for Stage 1: Identification – Meta-Analysis of Decision Making

Criterion 1: Understanding of What Makes a Strong Capstone Project

Meets Expectations

- Content: The student identifies at least three specific factors that contribute to a strong capstone project (e.g., personal interest, availability of research materials, complexity of the topic).
- Explanation: Provides a clear and detailed explanation for each factor, showing thoughtful consideration.
- Relevance: Factors are directly relevant to the successful completion of a semester-long capstone project.

Approaches Meeting Expectations

- Content: The student identifies two factors that contribute to a strong capstone project.
- Explanation: Provides some explanation for each factor but lacks depth or detail.
- Relevance: Factors are generally relevant but may be somewhat vague or not fully applicable to a capstone project.

Fails to Meet Expectations

- Content: The student identifies one or no factors, or the factors listed are irrelevant.
- Explanation: Explanations are missing, unclear, or do not demonstrate understanding.
- Relevance: Factors are not relevant to the capstone project.

Rubric for Reflecting on Decision-Making and Evaluating Biases

Meets Expectations

- Bias Reflection: The student clearly identifies **at least one specific bias or assumption** they had going into the decision-making process.
- Counterarguments: The student explains how they **considered the strongest counterarguments** to their chosen theory and how these were weighed against their final choice.
- Influence of Personal Interest: The student discusses how their **personal interests or preconceptions** might help sustain their engagement.
- Confidence in Decision: The student provides a clear statement of confidence in their choice, supported

Rubric for Final Decision: Conspiracy Theory Selection

Meets Expectations

- Decision Statement: The student provides a **clear and well-reasoned decision statement** identifying the conspiracy theory they will research.
- Interest: The student explains why they are personally interested in the theory and how that interest will
- Complexity: The student clearly explains the **complexity of competing hypotheses**, identifying at least two

Rubric for Stage 2: Consideration and Discretion

- **Explanation:** Provides a clear, logical explanation of how the project will help develop the skill.
- **Self-Awareness:** Demonstrates self-awareness by connecting the desired skills to personal growth goals.

Example Response (Approaches Meeting Expectations): *"I chose the Moon Landing Hoax theory because I was interested in why so many people believe it, even though there is overwhelming evidence against it. I want to develop my critical thinking skills, especially my ability to analyze primary sources and identify logical fallacies. I think this project will help me because I'll have to carefully examine the evidence for both sides, which will challenge my current beliefs and force me to think more deeply about how I form opinions."*

Approaches Meeting Expectations

- **Content:** The student identifies **one skill** they want to develop.
- **Explanation:** Clearly articulates how they want the project to challenge them in developing these skills.
- **Self-Awareness:** Demonstrates self-awareness by connecting the desired skills to personal growth goals.

Approaches Meeting Expectations

- **Content:** The student identifies **one skill** they want to develop.
- **Explanation:** Provides a vague explanation of how the project might help develop this skill but lacks detail.
- **Self-Awareness:** Shows limited connection between the skill and personal growth goals.

Approaches Meeting Expectations

- **Content:** The student identifies **one skill** they want to develop.
- **Explanation:** Provides no explanation, or the response is off-topic or unrelated to skill development.
- **Self-Awareness:** Does not demonstrate self-awareness or consideration of personal growth.

Example Response (Approaches Meeting Expectations): *"I chose the Moon Landing Hoax theory because I was interested in why so many people believe it, even though there is overwhelming evidence against it. I want to develop my critical thinking skills, especially my ability to analyze primary sources and identify logical fallacies. I think this project will help me because I'll have to carefully examine the evidence for both sides, which will challenge my current beliefs and force me to think more deeply about how I form opinions."*

Criterion 3: Consideration of Long-Term Impact on Semester Work

Fails to Meet Expectations

- **Content:** The student does not specify any skills they wish to develop.
- **Explanation:** Provides no explanation, or the response is off-topic or unrelated to skill development.
- **Self-Awareness:** Does not demonstrate self-awareness or consideration of personal growth.

Example Response (Fails to Meet Expectations): *"I chose the Moon Landing Hoax theory because it was interesting. I don't really know what I want to get out of it, I just thought it would be cool to research."*

Fails to Meet Expectations

- **Content:** The student does not specify any skills they wish to develop.
- **Explanation:** Provides no explanation, or the response is off-topic or unrelated to skill development.
- **Self-Awareness:** Does not demonstrate self-awareness or consideration of personal growth.

Example Response (Fails to Meet Expectations): *"I chose the Moon Landing Hoax theory because it was interesting. I don't really know what I want to get out of it, I just thought it would be cool to research."*

Criterion 2: Application of Provided Criteria

Meets Expectations

- **Content:** The student clearly explains how their project choice will affect their work throughout the semester, including potential challenges.
- **Challenges:** The student identifies **at least two challenges** they might face and explains how they plan to overcome them.
- **Variety:** The theories span a wide range of topics, showing that the student has explored multiple areas of interest (e.g., government cover-ups, historical events, science-related conspiracies).
- **Detail:** The summaries are clear, precise, and concise.
- **Explanation:** Clearly articulates how they want the project to challenge them in developing these skills.
- **Self-Awareness:** Demonstrates self-awareness by connecting the desired skills to personal growth goals.

Approaches Meeting Expectations

- **Content:** The student identifies **three to four conspiracy theories** and provides brief summaries for both the official story and the conspiracy theory.
- **Variety:** The theories may come from a narrower range of topics or show limited exploration.
- **Detail:** Summaries are somewhat vague or lack clear distinction between the official story and the conspiracy theory.

Approaches Meeting Expectations

- **Content:** The student identifies **one bias or assumption** but provides limited or general detail about how it might influence decision-making.
- **Explanation:** Provides a basic explanation of how the project might help develop this skill but lacks detail.
- **Self-Awareness:** Shows limited reflection on how the skill relates to personal growth.

Fails to Meet Expectations

- **Content:** The student identifies **one bias or assumption** but does not fully explain how they managed these influences.
- **Explanation:** Provides no explanation, or the response is off-topic or unrelated to skill development.
- **Self-Awareness:** Does not demonstrate self-awareness or consideration of personal growth.
- **Complexity:** The student mentions the existence of competing hypotheses but may only briefly describe them or miss important details or nuances.

Example Response (Approaches Meeting Expectations): *"I chose the Moon Landing Hoax theory because I was interested in why so many people believe it, even though there is overwhelming evidence against it. I want to develop my critical thinking skills, especially my ability to analyze primary sources and identify logical fallacies. I think this project will help me because I'll have to carefully examine the evidence for both sides, which will challenge my current beliefs and force me to think more deeply about how I form opinions."*

Criterion 3: Consideration of Long-Term Impact on Semester Work

Fails to Meet Expectations

- **Content:** The student's response is unclear or off-topic.

Example Response (Fails to Meet Expectations): *"I'll choose the JFK assassination conspiracy theory because I'm interested in it. I've watched a few documentaries about it, and I think it would be fun to research more."*

Meets Expectations

- **Challenges:** The student identifies **at least two challenges** they might face and explains how they plan to overcome them.
- **Content:** The student identifies **five or more conspiracy theories** and provides a brief summary of both the official story and the conspiracy theory for each.
- **Variety:** The theories span a wide range of topics, showing that the student has explored multiple areas of interest (e.g., government cover-ups, historical events, science-related conspiracies).
- **Detail:** The summaries are clear, precise, and concise.
- **Explanation:** Clearly articulates how they want the project to challenge them in developing these skills.
- **Self-Awareness:** Demonstrates self-awareness by connecting the desired skills to personal growth goals.

Approaches Meeting Expectations

- **Content:** The student identifies **three to four conspiracy theories** and provides brief summaries for both the official story and the conspiracy theory.
- **Variety:** The theories may come from a narrower range of topics or show limited exploration.
- **Detail:** Summaries are somewhat vague or lack clear distinction between the official story and the conspiracy theory.

Approaches Meeting Expectations

- **Content:** The student identifies **one bias or assumption** but provides limited or general detail about how it might influence decision-making.
- **Explanation:** Provides a basic explanation of how the project might help develop this skill but lacks detail.
- **Self-Awareness:** Shows limited reflection on how the skill relates to personal growth.

Fails to Meet Expectations

- **Content:** The student does not specify any skills they wish to develop.
- **Explanation:** Provides no explanation, or the response is off-topic or unrelated to skill development.
- **Self-Awareness:** Does not demonstrate self-awareness or consideration of personal growth.

Example Response (Fails to Meet Expectations): *"I chose the Moon Landing Hoax theory because it was interesting. I don't really know what I want to get out of it, I just thought it would be cool to research."*

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Criterion 2: Application of Provided Criteria

Meets Expectations

- **Content:** The student clearly explains how their project choice will affect their work throughout the semester, including potential challenges.
- **Challenges:** The student identifies **at least two challenges** they might face and explains how they plan to overcome them

- **Content:** The student evaluates **all five theories** based on the four provided criteria (research availability, interest level, complexity, and group/individual decision) and assigns a score from 1-5 for each criterion.
- **Explanation:** The reasoning is unclear or unsupported.
- **Depth:** Thoughtful consideration of what makes a theory interesting or challenging to research.

Fails to Meet Expectations

- **Decision Statement:** The student either does not provide a **decision statement** or provides one that is unclear or irrelevant to the assignment.
- **Depth:** The analysis lacks depth or is missing altogether.
- **Interest:** The student does not mention their personal interest or provides an unclear or irrelevant explanation.
- **Thinking:** Does not demonstrate forward-thinking or understanding of how the project choice affects future work.
- **Complexity:** The student fails to mention competing hypotheses or provides an unclear or incorrect explanation.

Approaches Meeting Expectations

- **Content:** The student evaluates **three to four theories** using the provided criteria.
- **Depth:** The analysis shows limited critical thinking or engagement with the material.
- **Meets Expectations:** The student must clearly identify biases, consider counterarguments, acknowledge gaps in knowledge, and provide a well-reasoned statement of confidence in their choice.

Fails to Meet Expectations

- **Content:** The student evaluates **fewer than three theories**, or the evaluations are incomplete or irrelevant.
- **Depth:** The analysis is superficial and lacks critical thinking.
- **Fails to Meet Expectations:** The student fails to reflect meaningfully on biases, counterarguments, personal influence, or their confidence in their choice.

Approaches Meeting Expectations

- **Clarity:** The response is generally understandable but may contain some vague statements.
- **Precision:** Answers address the questions but may include irrelevant details.
- **Conciseness:** Response is somewhat wordy or includes unnecessary repetition.
- **Organization:** The response lacks clear organization or blends answers together.
- **Approaches Meeting Expectations:** The student provides a decision statement and addresses most components (interest, complexity, evidence, challenges) but with limited depth.

Fails to Meet Expectations

- **Clarity:** The response is difficult to understand or contains ambiguous statements.
- **Precision:** Does not directly answer the questions; responses are off-topic.
- **Conciseness:** The response is overly verbose with significant filler content.
- **Organization:** The response is disorganized and confusing.

Approaches Meeting Expectations

- **Content:** The student develops **one additional criterion** or develops two but with a lack of depth.
- **Relevance:** The additional criterion is somewhat relevant but may not show strong connection to the project.
- **To "Meet Expectations"** for the assignment, the student must achieve "Meets Expectations" in **all four**

- **Explanation:** Provides a limited explanation or lacks clarity in justifying the additional criterion.

To "Approach Meeting Expectations," the student achieves "Approaches Meeting Expectations" in at least two criteria and no "Fails to Meet Expectations" in any criterion.

"Fails to Meet Expectations" applies if the student receives "Fails to Meet Expectations" in one or more criteria.

Fails to Meet Expectations

- **Content:** The student does not develop additional criteria or develops irrelevant or unclear criteria.
- **Relevance:** The criteria do not contribute meaningfully to the project selection process.
- **Explanation:** Provides no explanation or the explanation is unclear or irrelevant.

Example of a "Meets Expectations" Response

Question 1: *What do you think makes a strong capstone project?*

"A strong capstone project is built around a topic that deeply interests me, ensuring sustained engagement throughout the semester. It should have a manageable research scope, with access to credible sources to support a well-supported analysis. Additionally, the topic should be complex enough to allow for critical thinking and exploration of multiple perspectives."

Question 2: *How do you want this project to challenge you?*

"I want this project to challenge me by enhancing my research skills, particularly in evaluating the credibility of sources. I also aim to improve my critical thinking by analyzing conflicting information and forming my own evidence-based conclusions."

Question 3: *How does choosing this project now affect the direction of your work for the semester?*

"Choosing a compelling topic now will set the foundation for my semester. It will keep me motivated to dive deep into research and encourage me to ask meaningful questions. This early decision ensures that my work remains focused and allows me to manage my time effectively for a thorough investigation."

Meets Expectations

- **Content:** The student clearly articulates that the project is better suited for group or individual work, based on thoughtful consideration of the project's complexity, research needs, and their own strengths/weaknesses.
- **Explanation:** Provides a detailed explanation that weighs the pros and cons of working in a group vs. individually for each theory, considering how collaboration might affect the depth of analysis.
- **Relevance:** The decision is relevant to the project's scope and reflects a realistic understanding of the benefits and challenges of group vs. individual work.

Approaches Meeting Expectations

- **Content:** The student provides a decision about group or individual work but with less depth or explanation.
- **Explanation:** Provides some reasoning, but it may not fully consider how the work will be affected by the choice.
- **Relevance:** The decision may be somewhat relevant but lacks full engagement with the project's scope.

Fails to Meet Expectations

- **Content:** The student does not make a clear decision about group or individual work, or the decision is irrelevant to the project.
- **Explanation:** Provides no explanation, or the explanation is unclear or irrelevant.
- **Relevance:** The decision does not reflect realistic consideration of the project's scope or the student's strengths.

Criterion 5: Weighing Pros and Cons of Top 2 Theories

Meets Expectations

- **Content:** The student identifies their top **two conspiracy theories** and lists **at least three pros and three cons** for each.
- **Explanation:** Each pro and con is clearly explained, reflecting thoughtful consideration of the theory's merits and challenges.
- **Balance:** The pros and cons show a balanced approach, weighing both the positive and negative aspects of each theory objectively.

Approaches Meeting Expectations

- **Content:** The student identifies **two theories** but lists fewer than three pros and cons for each, or the pros and cons are less detailed.
- **Explanation:** Provides some explanation but may lack depth or balance in considering both positive and negative aspects.
- **Balance:** The analysis may lean heavily toward pros or cons, showing less objectivity.

Fails to Meet Expectations

- **Content:** The student identifies **fewer than two theories** or does not list meaningful pros and cons for each.
- **Explanation:** Provides little to no explanation, or the explanation is unclear or irrelevant.
- **Balance:** The pros and cons are unbalanced, or the student fails to provide both positive and negative considerations.

Scoring Guidelines

- **To "Meet Expectations"** for this stage, the student must achieve "Meets Expectations" in **all five criteria**.

- **To "Approach Meeting Expectations,"** the student achieves "Approaches Meeting Expectations" in at least three criteria and no "Fails to Meet Expectations" in any criterion.

- **"Fails to Meet Expectations"** applies if the student receives "Fails to Meet Expectations" in one or more criteria.